

LESSON 11

Verbal Suffixes: The Fast Direct Object

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF PREVIOUS CONCEPTS

Quick Summary

Throughout the course, we have used the preposition **l-** (ܠ) to mark the direct object of a verb. For example, *qṭal l-malkā* (he killed the king) or *qṭal l-ēh* (he killed him). We also learned how to attach pronominal suffixes to nouns and prepositions to indicate possession or indirect objects (*bayt-eh* = his house; *l-ēh* = to him).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. Translate: *Nēthūn* (from *’-t-y*, they will come).
2. What happens to the noun *malkā* when you add the suffix for “my”?
3. Translate: *’Eqṭūl*.
4. How do you say “to us” using the preposition *l-*?
5. How does Syriac traditionally mark a definite direct object?

SECTION 2: THE VERBAL SUFFIX — OVERVIEW

While *qṭal l-ēh* (“he killed him”) is perfectly valid Syriac, Semitic languages prefer a tighter, faster construction for pronoun objects. They allow you to attach the object pronoun **directly to the verb itself**.

This creates a single, highly compressed word that contains the Action, the Subject, and the Direct Object.

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: Object Suffixes on Verbs

- **Hebrew:** *קָטַל־וֹ* (*qṭāl-ō* — he killed him). The suffix *-ō* is attached directly to the perfect verb.
- **Arabic:** *قَاتَلَ-ا-هُ* (*qāṭal-a-hu* — he killed him). The suffix *-hu* is attached directly to the verb.
- **Syriac:** *ܩܬܠ-ܗ* (*qāṭl-eh* — he killed him). The suffix *-eh* attaches directly, altering the internal vowels of the verb.

- **Greek/Latin:** Indo-European languages generally keep the object pronoun separate (e.g., *auton apektelnen, eum interfecit*), though spoken Romance languages often compress them into clitics (Spanish: *matarlo*).

Core Principle: A suffix attached to a noun is possessive (“his house”). A suffix attached to a verb is the direct object (“he killed him”). The suffix *never* represents the subject of the verb.

SECTION 3: MORPHOLOGY OF VERBAL SUFFIXES (PEAL PERFECT)

When you attach a pronoun suffix to a verb, the vowels inside the verb often shift to accommodate the new rhythm. We will focus on attaching suffixes to the 3rd person masculine singular Peal perfect (*qṭal*, “he killed”).

1. Connecting Vowels (The “Nun” buffer)

Sometimes, attaching a suffix directly to a verb ending sounds clunky or ambiguous. Syriac frequently uses a *Nun* (n) as a buffer consonant.

- “He killed me”: Not *qṭal-y*, but *qṭl-anī*.
- “He killed us”: *qṭl-an*.

2. Vocalization Shifts

When adding an object suffix to *qṭal* (which has no vowel between the first two consonants: q-ṭ-a-l), the vowel shifts back to separate the first two consonants.

- *qṭal + eh* → *qṭl-eh* (q-a-ṭ-l-e-h).

3. Meaning

Qṭleh means “He killed him”.

- Subject: He (inherent in the base verb form).
 - Object: Him (the suffix).
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SECTION 4: VERBAL SUFFIX PARADIGM (ROOT Q-Ṭ-L)

Here is how the 3rd person masculine singular Perfect (*qṭal*, “he killed”) takes all the object suffixes.

OBJECT (ENGLISH)	SUFFIX FORM	ATTACHED TO QṬAL (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	TRANSLATION
me (1 c.sg.)	ܐ- (-anī)	ܩܬܠܐܝ	qaṭlanī	he killed me
you (2 m.sg.)	ܟ- (-āk)	ܩܬܠܟ	qaṭlāk	he killed you (m)
you (2 f.sg.)	ܟܝ- (-ēky)	ܩܬܠܟܝ	qaṭlēky	he killed you (f)
him (3 m.sg.)	ܐܝ- (-eh)	ܩܬܠܐܝܗ	qaṭleh	he killed him
her (3 f.sg.)	ܐܝܬܐ- (-āh)	ܩܬܠܐܝܬܐ	qaṭlāh	he killed her
us (1 c.pl.)	ܐܢ- (-an)	ܩܬܠܐܢ	qaṭlan	he killed us
you (2 m.pl.)	ܟܝܢ- (-kūn)	ܩܬܠܟܝܢ	qaṭlkūn	he killed you (mpl)
you (2 f.pl.)	ܟܝܢܝ- (-kēn)	ܩܬܠܟܝܢܝ	qaṭlkēn	he killed you (fpl)
them (3 m.pl.)	ܐܝܢܐ- (-hūn)	ܩܬܠܐܝܢܐ	qaṭlhūn	he killed them (m)
them (3 f.pl.)	ܐܝܢܐܝܬܐ- (-hēn)	ܩܬܠܐܝܢܐܝܬܐ	qaṭlhēn	he killed them (f)

Note: Suffixes can also be attached to the Imperfect and Imperative forms (e.g., “Kill him!”). The suffixes remain fundamentally identical, though the connecting vowels may vary slightly.

SECTION 5: SYNTAX COMPARISON TABLE

How to say “He killed him” three ways in Syriac:

STYLE	SYRIAC TRANSLIT	BREAKDOWN	NOTES
Independent Obj	qṭal l-ēh	he-killed to-him	Standard, highly common.
Verbal Suffix	qaṭl-eh	he-killed-him	Fast, literary, deeply Semitic.
Demonstrative	qṭal l-hū	he-killed to-that-one	Used for emphasis (“That guy”).

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (HEALING, NATURE, COMMUNITY)

Many verbs related to interpersonal action (healing, forgiving, striking) frequently take verbal suffixes.

ROOT (PEAL/APHEL)	VERB EXAMPLE (3 M.S)	MEANING	WITH 1ST PERSON SUFFIX (-ANĪ)
פ.ר.ק (p-r-q)	praq (Peal)	to save, deliver	parqanī (he saved me)
א.ש.י (ʾ-s-y)	ʾasī (Aphel)	to heal (causative)	ʾasyanī (he healed me)
פ.ב.ק (š-b-q)	šbaq (Peal)	to leave, forgive	šbaqanī (he left me)*
מ.ח.י (m-ḥ-y)	mḥā (Peal)	to strike, hit	mḥānī (he struck me)
ק.ר.י (q-r-y)	qrā (Peal)	to call	qrānī (he called me)
נ.ח.מ (n-ḥ-m)	naḥḥem (Paael)	to raise (the dead), revive	naḥḥmanī (he revived me)
ח.ט.י (ḥ-ṭ-y)	ḥṭā (Peal)	to sin	(intransitive usually)
כ.ר.ח (k-r-h)	kurhānā (Noun)	illness, sickness	
ח.ט.י (ḥ-ṭ-y)	ḥṭtā (Noun)	sin	
נ.פ.ל (n-p-l)	npal (Peal)	to fall	npal b-kurhānā (fell ill)
ת.ב.ר (t-b-r)	tbar (Peal)	to break	tabranī (he broke me)

*Note: Forgiving is usually expressed with **ל-**: šbaq lī (he forgave to me).

SECTION 7: THE STORY – PART 11

The Healing

Narrative note: The king, having fallen ill, begs for physical and spiritual salvation. Notice the dense use of verbal suffixes (fast direct objects) as he pleads with Yukhannan.

Sentence 1

וּבְיוֹמָא הַהוּא נְפַל מַלְכָּא בְּכֻרְחָנָא בִּישָׁא. וּבְיוֹמָא (and-in-day) haw (that) npal (fell) malkā (the-king) b-kurhānā (in-illness) bišā (evil/bad). → And in that day, the king fell into a severe illness.

Sentence 2

ወ- 'etā l-wāt Yūḥannan, w-npal qdāmāw-hy, w- 'emar l-ēh:
 w- 'etā (and-came) l-wāt (to-the-presence-of) Yūḥannan (John), w-npal (and-fell) qdāmāw-hy (before-
 him), w- 'emar (and-said) l-ēh (to-him): → And he came to Yukhannan, and fell before him, and said to
 him:

Sentence 3

ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ 'asy-anī men kurhān-y, w-parq-anī men mawtā! 'asy-anī (heal-me
 [Aphel Impv]) men (from) kurhān-y (illness-my), w-parq-anī (and-save-me [Peal Impv]) men (from)
 mawtā (death)! → “Heal me from my illness, and save me from death!”

Sentence 4

ወ- 'šbūq lī ḥṭitt-y d-saggī 'ā hī! w- 'šbūq (and-forgive [Peal Impv]) lī (to-me)
 ḥṭitt-y (sin-my) d-saggī 'ā (which-is-great/much) hī (she-[is])! → “And forgive me my sin, which is great!”

Sentence 5

ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ q-rāwḥy Yūḥannan l-Alāhā w- 'emar: q-rāwḥy (he-called-him [3msg Peal Perf.
 of q-r-y + 3msg obj. suffix]) Yūḥannan (John) l-Alāhā (to-God) w- 'emar (and-said): → Yukhannan called
 upon God and said: *Note: III-Yodh verbs contract the final yodh before the suffix: q-rā + -wh + y → q-rāwḥy.*

Sentence 6

ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ Alāhā nneḥt-āk, w-naḥyē-k hāšā. Alāhā (God) nneḥt-āk (he-will-give-rest-
 you), w-naḥyē-k (and-he-will-give-life/save-you [Aphel Imperfect]) hāšā (now). → “God will give you rest,
 and will save you now.”

Sentence 7

ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ w- 'asy-eh Alāhā b-ṭaybūtt-eh. w- 'asy-eh (and-he-healed-him) Alāhā (God)
 b-ṭaybūtt-eh (by-grace-his). → And God healed him by his grace.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Suffix Identification

Identify the verb root, the tense/form (if you can), and the person/gender of the suffix.

1. ለጥፋት ሕይወቴ (qatlhūn)

2. ܦܪܩܢܝ (parqanī)
3. ܐܣܝܐܩ (ʾasyāk)
4. ܩܪܝܬܐ (qrāwhy — III-Yodh verb q-r-y with 3msg direct object suffix; final yodh contracts before suffix)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

Take the Peal perfect 3 m.sg verb *šbaq* (he left/abandoned) and attach suffixes to mean:

1. He abandoned me.
2. He abandoned us.
3. He abandoned her.
4. He abandoned them (m).

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following clauses featuring verbal suffixes.

1. Mḥānī barnāšā bišā b-tar ʿ ā.
2. Alāhā qaṭleh l-malkā tammān. (Note: Syriac sometimes uses both the suffix *and* the preposition **l-** for extreme emphasis).
3. ʾ Emar malkā: “Parqanī!”
4. Alāhā ʾ asyan b-melt-eh.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following actions into single-word Syriac verbs with suffixes (using 3rd m.sg *qṭal* base).

1. He killed us.
2. He saved (praq) him.
3. He left (šbaq) you (m.sg).
4. He struck (mḥā) them (m.pl).

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. What three imperative commands does the sick king give to Yukhannan?
2. Why does the king ask for forgiveness regarding his sin?

3. Who ultimately performs the healing in sentence 7?

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. They will come.
2. It drops the Emphatic Alaph and takes the suffix **-y** : *malky*.
3. I will kill.
4. *lān*.
5. By placing the preposition **l-** before the object.

Exercise 1: Suffix Identification

1. Root: *q-ṭ-l*. Suffix: 3rd m.pl (them). He killed them.
2. Root: *p-r-q*. Suffix: 1st c.sg (me). He delivered me.
3. Root: *'-s-y*. Suffix: 2nd m.sg (you). He healed you.
4. Root: *q-r-y*. Suffix: 3rd m.sg (him). He called him.

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. šbaqanī (or šabqanī)
2. šabqan
3. šabqāh
4. šabqhūn

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. The evil man struck me in the gate.
2. God killed him, the king, there.
3. The king said: "Save me!"
4. God healed us (*'asy-an*) by his word.

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. qaṭlan

2. parqeh
3. šabqāk
4. mḥāhūn

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. Heal me ('aṣyanī), save me (parqanī), forgive me (šbūq lī).
2. Because it is great (saggī 'ā hī).
3. God (Alāhā).

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

THE VERBAL SUFFIX PARADIGM (He killed...)

ENGLISH	SUFFIX ON VERB	EXAMPLE
...me	-anī	qaṭlanī (he killed me)
...you(m)	-āk	qaṭlāk (he killed you)
...you(f)	-ēky	qaṭlēky (he killed you)
...him	-eh	qaṭleh (he killed him)
...her	-āh	qaṭlāh (he killed her)
...us	-an	qaṭlan (he killed us)
...them(m)	-hūn	qaṭlhūn (he killed them)

DOUBLE DETERMINATION RULE

Sometimes Syriac uses the verb suffix AND the preposition **l-** in the same sentence. This is called *prolepsis* or double determination, used for clarity or emphasis. *Qaṭl-eh l-malkā* = He killed him, [namely] the king.

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson's vocabulary, focusing on verbs and nouns related to interpersonal action (commonly taking object suffixes) and related

abstract/derived nouns.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܢܫܟ	nasak	verb	to pour, cast	common with suffixes
ܕܒܥܩ	dābeq	verb	to cling, adhere	transposes object suffix
ܕܒܪ	gāder	verb	to fence, hedge in	takes object suffix
ܠܥܕ	lā ‘ ad	verb	to witness, testify	object suffix usage
ܫܢܐ	šānē	verb	to change, alter	object suffix common
ܫܪܒ	šāreb	verb	to drink	takes object suffix
ܦܫܐ	pāsa ‘	verb	to cut, prune	object suffix frequent
ܡܚܬ	mehaṭ	verb	to cover, conceal	takes object suffix
ܙܗܡ	zaḥem	verb	to strengthen, mightily	object suffix usage
ܕܠܗ	dāleh	verb	to draw water	takes object suffix
ܓܘܐܓ	gwag	verb	to plunder, rob	object suffix common
ܪܡܕ	rāmed	verb	to strengthen, make firm	takes object suffix
ܢܬܐܓ	nātag	verb	to pull, draw	object suffix usage
ܫܠܐ	sāla ‘	verb	to lift, raise	takes object suffix
ܕܒܥܫ	dāgaš	verb	to push, press	object suffix frequent
ܦܕܐ	pāda ‘	verb	to inform, make known	transposes object suffix
ܥܡܕ	‘ āmed	verb	to stand firm	object suffix usage
ܪܟܒ	rāk eb	verb	to ride, mount	takes object suffix

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܡܢܥܐ	menag	verb	to prevent, hinder	object suffix common
ܥܡܪܐ	‘āmar	verb	to dwell, inhabit	transposes object suffix
ܚܣܪܐ	ḥāsar	verb	to lack, be deprived	takes object suffix
ܕܡܪܢܐ	gəmrānā	m. noun	completion, fulfillment	derived from g-m-r
ܡܕܘܚܕܐ	pədūḥūtā	f. noun	mercy, compassion	related to p-d-ḥ
ܢܫܠܬܐ	nəskūtā	f. noun	pouring, libation	from n-s-k
ܕܠܒܩܬܐ	dəbqūtā	f. noun	clinging, adherence	from d-b-q
ܫܡܝܪܐ	šəmirā	m. noun	watch, guard	from š-m-r
ܕܕܢܐ	‘ūddānā	m. noun	answer, response	from ‘-w-d
ܩܒܠܐܢܐ	qūbbəlānā	m. noun	acceptance, reception	from q-b-l
ܫܪܒܬܐ	šərbūtā	f. noun	drinking	from š-r-b
ܡܕܠܘܬܐ	mədəlūtā	f. noun	poverty, humiliation	from m-d-l